

at the foreign bank was a good friend of Shroff's. He came over to discuss his predicament with Shroff.

'Ahuja told Shroff about the company's strengths and bemoaned the lack of interest in the issue.

"The company may be good, but the market is not confident about it," Shroff told him.

"What is to be done for that?" Ahuja asked.

"I will tell you," Shroff told him, calling out to me, "Just ask Kamani to come to my office and tell him there is a new issue I want to know his views on." He then turned to Ahuja and said: "While I am talking to Kamani, you will not utter a single word."

'Ahuja agreed.

'A few minutes later, I returned with Kamani in tow.

'After some small talk, Shroff asked Kamani what he thought of the Milk Food Products issue.

"*Kuch dum nahin hain issue mein.* Firstly, you can never trust Delhi-based companies. Six months later, there will be no milk, no food and no products," Kamani remarked casually.

'I could see that Ahuja was trying hard to restrain himself from having a go at Kamani. But having given his word to Shroff, there was nothing he could do. After Kamani left, Shroff told Ahuja: "There is a perception problem. The only way you can fix it is by creating a buzz in the grey market. Unless you are able to do that, the issue is doomed."

'Ahuja agreed, and gave Shroff the mandate to buy as many shares of Milk Food from the grey market as he could. Shroff did that, and as a result the premium for Milk Food shares in the grey market shot up dramatically. Players who had short-sold the shares realized they could be in for trouble on the day of listing and tried to cover up their positions. This frantic buying only fired up the prices even more.

'Staring at a huge loss, the gang of short-sellers approached the BSE president asking him to put a cap on the price of the stock on listing day. Since it was not possible to do that without being accused of bias, the president decided to do the next best thing. He called for a meeting with Shroff and a couple of other brokers to whom the short-sellers owed big money.

'The president requested that Shroff and the issue manager reach a settlement with the bear syndicate. Shroff was a bit miffed since it would